How to Earn Money on YouTube: 10 Real Ways in 2026

YouTube is no longer just a platform for watching videos. For many creators, it has become a place to build an audience, promote products, offer services, work with brands, and generate income from content. The good news is that you do not necessarily need a huge channel before exploring ways to make money on YouTube.

If you are searching for how to earn money on YouTube, the first thing to understand is that YouTube income does not come from ads alone. Depending on your channel, you can earn through the YouTube Partner Program, affiliate marketing, sponsorships, memberships, fan support, digital products, merchandise, and live-streaming.

Some monetization methods require you to meet YouTube's eligibility requirements, while others can be started independently of YouTube's advertising system. That means a small creator can begin building revenue before reaching the full advertising threshold.



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In this guide, we will explain 10 real ways to earn money on YouTube in 2026, how each method works, what you need to get started, and what factors can affect your actual earnings.

Is It Really Possible to Make Money on YouTube?

Yes, but YouTube income usually takes time to develop.

Uploading a few videos does not automatically generate significant revenue. Your results can depend on your topic, audience, video quality, traffic, viewer location, engagement, advertiser demand, product relevance, and consistency.

A gaming channel, for example, may monetize differently from a personal-finance channel or a technology tutorial channel. Even two creators covering the same subject can have very different earnings because their audiences and traffic sources are different.

This is why subscriber count alone should not be treated as a measure of income.

A smaller channel with highly engaged viewers may generate money through affiliate sales, sponsorships, products, or memberships, while a much larger channel may rely mainly on advertising.

YouTube Partner Program Has Different Monetization Levels

The YouTube Partner Program is the platform's main monetization system, but not every feature becomes available at the same stage.

Eligible creators in supported locations can access certain fan-funding features at a lower threshold, while full advertising revenue requires the higher YPP eligibility requirements.

For full ad revenue sharing, creators generally need:

- 1,000 subscribers
- Either 4,000 valid public watch hours during the previous 12 months or 10 million valid public Shorts views during the previous 90 days
- Compliance with YouTube's monetization policies
- A channel that passes YouTube's review process

There are also lower YPP entry requirements in eligible regions for features such as fan funding and shopping-related tools.

Because YouTube can update its requirements, always check the current eligibility information inside YouTube Studio or YouTube's official creator resources before planning your income around a particular threshold.

You Don't Have to Wait for Ad Revenue

One of the biggest misconceptions about YouTube monetization is that you must reach 1,000 subscribers before you can make any money.

That is not necessarily true.

Affiliate marketing, sponsorships, digital products, services, and external memberships can potentially generate revenue without relying on YouTube ad monetization.

For example, a creator who publishes gaming tutorials could recommend gaming accessories through affiliate links. A creator who teaches Photoshop could sell templates or a course. A fitness creator could work with a relevant brand.

The key is matching the monetization method to the reason people watch your videos.

10 Real Ways to Earn Money on YouTube

1. Earn Through YouTube Ad Revenue

The YouTube Partner Program is the most familiar way to monetize a channel.

Once your channel qualifies for full YPP advertising revenue and passes YouTube's review, eligible videos can generate advertising revenue. YouTube shares revenue from eligible Watch Page ads with creators according to its current revenue-sharing terms.

However, there is no universal amount that YouTube pays for every 1,000 views.

Your actual RPM can vary because of factors such as:

- Viewer location
- Content category

- Advertiser demand
- Time of year
- Video length
- Audience characteristics
- Number of monetized views
- Ad availability

For that reason, claims such as “YouTube always pays $X for 1,000 views” are misleading.

Your own YouTube Analytics data is much more useful once your channel begins generating revenue.

How YouTube Ad Revenue Works

Advertisers pay for advertising opportunities around eligible content. YouTube processes the advertising revenue and applies its applicable revenue share before the creator receives their portion.

Not every view produces an advertisement, and not every viewer is equally valuable to advertisers.

A channel receiving 100,000 views can therefore earn a very different amount from another channel receiving the same number of views.

This makes ad revenue more suitable as one part of a broader monetization strategy rather than something to rely on blindly.

2. Monetize YouTube Shorts

Short-form videos have become an important part of YouTube's creator ecosystem.

YouTube Shorts use a different advertising model from traditional long-form videos. Advertising revenue generated around Shorts is pooled, and eligible creators receive an allocated share based on qualified Shorts activity under YouTube's current system.

Creators who qualify for full YPP ad sharing can participate in Shorts monetization.

One important point is that Shorts Feed watch time does not count toward the 4,000 public watch-hour requirement used for the long-form eligibility route.

Why Shorts Can Still Be Valuable

Even if Shorts revenue is not your primary income source, short-form videos can help you reach new viewers.

A creator can use Shorts to introduce an idea, highlight a longer video, answer a common question, or turn existing footage into additional content.

For example, a gaming creator could turn a five-minute gameplay highlight into several short clips. A technology channel could extract quick tips from a longer tutorial.

Shorts can therefore play two roles: audience growth and monetization.

3. Turn on YouTube Channel Memberships

Channel memberships allow eligible creators to offer paid monthly memberships to viewers.

Members can receive benefits such as custom badges, exclusive posts, members-only videos, emojis, live chats, or other perks selected by the creator.

This model works particularly well when viewers feel connected to a channel and want additional content or recognition.

YouTube shares eligible membership revenue with creators after applicable deductions according to its current terms.

How to Make Memberships Useful

Do not create complicated membership levels just because the feature allows them.

Start with benefits you can consistently deliver.

For example, a gaming channel might provide:

- Members-only gaming sessions
- Early access to videos
- Private community posts
- Special livestreams
- Custom badges and emojis

The biggest mistake is promising so many perks that managing the membership becomes more work than the revenue justifies.

A simple offer that you can maintain every month is usually easier to manage.

4. Make Money From Super Chat, Super Stickers, and Super Thanks

Fan-funding tools provide another way to earn money directly from your audience.

Super Chat and Super Stickers are primarily associated with live streams and Premieres, allowing viewers to pay for highlighted messages or stickers.

Super Thanks lets viewers financially support eligible content outside traditional live-chat interactions.

These features can be particularly useful for channels with an active community.

Imagine a gaming creator streaming a new game launch. Viewers may use Super Chat to ask questions, support the stream, or have their messages highlighted.

Why Fan Support Can Be Valuable

Advertising depends heavily on views and ad demand.

Fan support works differently because the revenue comes directly from viewers who choose to contribute.

That does not mean every viewer will pay. In fact, most viewers may never use these features.

But a relatively small number of highly engaged fans can provide an additional revenue stream for creators who regularly interact with their community.

5. Get Paid Through Brand Sponsorships

You do not necessarily need to wait for YouTube's advertising program before working with brands.

Sponsorships allow companies to pay creators to feature products, services, apps, games, or other offers in their content.

The amount a creator receives can vary dramatically. There is no universal sponsorship rate because deals can depend on:

- Average video views
- Audience demographics
- Content niche
- Engagement
- Campaign duration
- Number of videos
- Deliverables
- Usage rights
- Exclusivity
- Brand budget

A creator with a smaller but highly targeted audience may be attractive to a brand because the audience closely matches its customers.

How to Find Sponsorship Opportunities

Start by creating a simple media kit.

Include information such as your niche, average recent views, audience demographics, geographic distribution, engagement information, and examples of previous collaborations if available.

You can approach brands directly or use creator marketplaces that connect businesses with influencers.

Always clearly disclose paid partnerships and follow the advertising and disclosure rules applicable to your location.

The relationship should also make sense for your audience. Promoting completely unrelated products simply because a company offers money can damage viewer trust.

6. Earn With Affiliate Marketing

Affiliate marketing is one of the most accessible ways to monetize YouTube without relying entirely on ad revenue.

The basic idea is simple: you recommend a product or service and receive a commission when viewers complete a qualifying action through your affiliate link.

The commission structure depends entirely on the affiliate program.

Some programs pay a percentage of the purchase price. Others may pay a fixed amount for a signup, subscription, lead, or other qualifying action.

YouTube Content That Works Well With Affiliates

Affiliate marketing tends to work naturally with content that helps viewers make decisions.

Examples include:

- Product reviews
- Buying guides
- Software tutorials
- Gaming accessory comparisons
- “How to” videos
- Setup guides
- Technology recommendations
- Educational tools
- Creator equipment reviews

Suppose you publish a video explaining how to build a budget gaming setup. You could include affiliate links to compatible keyboards, mice, headphones, monitors, or other products.

The video can continue generating affiliate clicks long after publication if viewers keep discovering it through search.

Be Transparent

Do not recommend something solely because it pays a higher commission.

Your audience needs to trust your recommendations.

If you use affiliate links, disclose the relationship clearly and follow the relevant advertising requirements.

7. Sell Merchandise Through YouTube

A YouTube audience can also become a customer base for merchandise.

Creators can use print-on-demand services to sell products without purchasing large quantities of inventory upfront.

Depending on the available integration and eligibility requirements, merchandise can be displayed alongside YouTube content through supported shopping features.

Products might include:

- T-shirts
- Hoodies
- Mugs
- Posters
- Stickers
- Accessories
- Creator-branded products

How Print-on-Demand Merch Works

With print-on-demand, the creator creates a design and lists it on a supported platform.

When someone purchases the product, the fulfillment provider handles production and shipping according to its service terms.

Your potential profit is generally the selling price minus the product's base cost and applicable fees.

This means a $30 shirt is not automatically $30 of profit.

Before promoting merchandise heavily, order samples whenever possible. Check the print quality, sizing, packaging, and overall customer experience.

Merch works particularly well when your channel has recognizable branding, catchphrases, characters, community jokes, or other elements viewers already identify with.

8. Build a Patreon Membership

Patreon can provide another way for creators to earn recurring revenue from their most loyal viewers.

Instead of relying entirely on YouTube's built-in membership system, creators can send interested viewers to an external membership page.

Depending on the creator's offer, members might receive:

- Bonus videos
- Behind-the-scenes content
- Exclusive posts
- Private communities
- Early access
- Downloadable resources
- Special livestreams

Patreon charges applicable platform and payment-related fees according to the creator's plan and account terms.

Focus on a Clear Membership Benefit

People are unlikely to pay simply because a creator asks them to.

They need a reason.

A useful membership offer might provide additional educational material, exclusive gaming sessions, downloadable resources, private community access, or content that cannot be found on the public channel.

Keep the workload realistic.

If ten paying members create twenty hours of extra work every month, the economics may not make sense. Build rewards that provide genuine value without creating an unsustainable schedule.

9. Sell Digital Products or Courses

If your YouTube videos teach something useful, you can turn that knowledge into a product.

Digital products can include:

- Templates
- Presets
- Guides
- Checklists
- Workbooks
- Design assets
- Spreadsheets
- Study materials
- Tutorials
- Mini-courses
- Full online courses

The advantage is that you create the product once and can potentially sell it repeatedly.

Use Your Videos to Discover Product Ideas

Your audience can tell you what they want.

Look at recurring questions in your comments.

If viewers repeatedly ask for a template, create one.

If they want a deeper explanation of a topic, consider a structured course or downloadable guide.

This approach is more useful than spending months building a product nobody asked for.

Platforms such as Gumroad and other digital-commerce services can be used to sell downloads and educational products, but always review the current platform fees and payout requirements before choosing one.

10. Earn From YouTube Live Streams

Live streaming creates opportunities that regular uploaded videos do not always provide.

Creators can potentially monetize live audiences through YouTube fan-funding tools, sponsorships, affiliate links, memberships, merchandise, and third-party tipping services.

Gaming is a popular example, but live streaming can work for many subjects.

You could stream:

- Gaming sessions
- Tutorials
- Q&A sessions
- Product demonstrations
- Coding sessions
- Study sessions
- Creative work
- Interviews
- Commentary
- Educational discussions

Build a Reason to Return

A successful livestream is usually more than turning on a camera.

Give viewers a reason to come back at a predictable time.

For example, a creator might stream every Friday evening, run a weekly Q&A, host community gaming sessions, or demonstrate a new project.

Third-party tipping services can also be used alongside YouTube's native fan-support features, subject to their own terms and payment processing rules.

However, tips are audience-driven and should never be treated as guaranteed income.

Comparing Different Ways to Earn Money on YouTube

Each monetization method has a different business model.

Method	Main Revenue Source	Requires YPP?	Income Style	Main Challe
YouTube ads	Advertising	Yes	Based on eligible views/ad revenue	Need consis
Shorts ads	Shorts revenue sharing	Yes	Based on allocated Shorts revenue	High view v

Method	Main Revenue Source	Requires YPP?	Income Style	Main Challe
Memberships	Monthly viewer payments	Eligible YPP tier	Recurring	Maintaining value
Super Chat/Thanks	Viewer support	Eligible YPP tier	Audience-driven	Depends on engagemen
Sponsorships	Brand campaigns	No	Per campaign	Finding suit brands
Affiliate marketing	Product commissions	No	Per qualifying action	Generating intent traffi
Merchandise	Product margins	Depends on integration	Per sale	Creating de
Patreon	Paid memberships	No	Recurring	Converting into membe
Digital products	Product sales	No	Per sale	Creating so people wan
Live-stream tips	Viewer contributions	No specific YPP requirement for third-party tips	Audience-driven	Building a li community

The most suitable option depends on the type of audience you have.

A tutorial channel may naturally sell digital products. A product-review channel can use affiliate marketing. A gaming community may respond well to memberships, live streams, sponsorships, and merchandise.

You do not have to choose only one.

How to Build Multiple YouTube Income Streams

One of the most practical ways to grow YouTube income is to combine different monetization methods.

For example, a technology channel could have:

Long-form videos → Ad revenue

Product reviews → Affiliate commissions

Large audience → Brand sponsorships

Loyal viewers → Memberships

Tutorial content → Digital products

This creates several opportunities from the same content ecosystem.

A single video might generate advertising revenue, affiliate clicks, and new subscribers.

That is more resilient than relying entirely on one source.

How Many Views Do You Need to Make Money on YouTube?

There is no fixed number of views that guarantees a specific amount of money.

If you are talking specifically about ad revenue, the important metric is not simply views but the revenue generated from those views.

Your RPM can change depending on audience, niche, geography, season, advertiser demand, and other factors.

For affiliate marketing, you may need far fewer views if the audience has strong purchase intent.

For sponsorships, brands may care more about average views and audience relevance than total lifetime views.

For digital products, a small audience can sometimes generate sales if the product solves a clear problem.

This is why asking “How many YouTube views do I need to make $100?” does not have one universal answer.

Can You Make Money on YouTube Without 1,000 Subscribers?

Yes.

The 1,000-subscriber requirement is associated with full YPP advertising eligibility, not every possible way to earn money from an audience.

You can potentially earn through affiliate marketing, sponsorships, services, digital products, merchandise, or external memberships before reaching that milestone.

Eligible creators in supported regions can also access certain YPP fan-funding and shopping features at lower thresholds.

This gives new channels several ways to build a business while working toward full YouTube monetization.

How Long Does It Take to Make Money on YouTube?

There is no standard timeline.

Some creators make their first affiliate sale quickly. Others spend months publishing content before receiving meaningful income.

Advertising generally takes longer because you first need to meet YPP eligibility requirements and then build enough traffic to generate useful revenue.

The timeline can depend on:

- Upload frequency
- Content quality
- Search demand
- Competition
- Niche
- Audience retention
- Click-through rate
- Viewer loyalty
- Promotion
- Monetization strategy

Instead of setting an unrealistic deadline, focus on measurable milestones.

Your first goal could be publishing ten useful videos.

Then aim for your first 100 subscribers, first affiliate conversion, first sponsorship inquiry, first product sale, or first monetized video.

Common YouTube Monetization Mistakes to Avoid

Making money on YouTube is not just about finding a monetization button.

There are several mistakes that can hurt a channel's growth or income.

Buying Subscribers and Views

Artificial engagement can create misleading numbers and may violate platform rules.

A channel needs real viewers who actually watch, interact, and return.

Focusing Only on Subscriber Count

Subscribers are useful, but they are not the same thing as revenue.

A smaller audience with strong purchase intent can sometimes be more valuable for affiliate marketing or products than a much larger audience with little commercial intent.

Accepting Every Sponsorship

A sponsorship that does not fit your audience can damage trust.

Consider whether the product is genuinely relevant before accepting a deal.

Ignoring Affiliate Disclosures

If you receive compensation or commissions from recommendations, make the relationship clear.

Transparency protects both your audience and your business.

Spending Too Much on Equipment

You do not need an expensive studio to test a YouTube idea.

A modern smartphone, decent lighting, understandable audio, and useful content can be enough to start.

Upgrade your equipment when your content actually requires it.

Depending on One Income Stream

YouTube policies, advertiser demand, audience behavior, and platform features can change.

Building several legitimate revenue sources can make your creator business more flexible.

How to Start Making Money on YouTube

If you are starting from zero, do not try all ten methods simultaneously.

Choose one topic you can consistently create content about.

Then identify what your audience wants.

For example, if you are making gaming tutorials, look for questions players repeatedly search for. If you create technology videos, focus on problems people need solved. If you teach a skill, build videos around beginner questions and common mistakes.

Once you have useful content, select a monetization method that naturally fits.

An early-stage channel might begin with affiliate links or a simple digital product.

As the audience grows, sponsorships, memberships, merchandise, and YouTube's native monetization features can be added.

This creates a progression instead of forcing every new channel to depend on advertising immediately.

What Doesn't Work When Trying to Make Money on YouTube?

Be careful with anyone promising guaranteed YouTube income.

There is no legitimate system that can guarantee a particular amount of money from a channel.

Avoid services offering fake subscribers, artificial views, guaranteed monetization approval, or secret methods to bypass YouTube's policies.

Also be cautious when someone asks for an upfront payment in exchange for guaranteed earnings.

The FTC has warned consumers about work-from-home and online income scams that promise easy money, pressure people to act quickly, or require payment before receiving supposed earnings.

A genuine YouTube business is built around real content, real viewers, and legitimate transactions.

Final Thoughts

Learning how to earn money on YouTube is less about finding one magic monetization method and more about building an audience that has a reason to watch your content.

YouTube ads can provide an important revenue source after you qualify for the Partner Program, but they are only one option.

Affiliate marketing can monetize purchase-focused videos. Sponsorships can connect creators with relevant businesses. Memberships and fan support can turn loyal viewers into recurring revenue. Digital products and courses can turn expertise into products, while merchandise can give a strong community another way to support the channel.

The right combination depends on your niche, audience, skills, and goals.

Start with useful content, keep your costs under control, study your analytics, and add monetization methods as your audience develops. Most importantly, treat YouTube as a long-term content business rather than a shortcut to instant income.

FAQs About How to Earn Money on YouTube

How can I earn money on YouTube?

You can earn money on YouTube through advertising, Shorts revenue sharing, channel memberships, Super Chat, Super Thanks, sponsorships, affiliate marketing, merchandise, digital products, courses, Patreon, and live-stream tips.

How many subscribers do I need to make money on YouTube?

You do not necessarily need 1,000 subscribers to earn money from a YouTube audience. Some external monetization methods can work with a small audience, while eligible YPP features have their own requirements. Full ad revenue sharing generally requires 1,000 subscribers plus the required watch-hour or Shorts-view threshold.

How much does YouTube pay for 1,000 views?

There is no fixed payment for 1,000 views. Earnings can vary significantly depending on RPM, audience location, niche, advertiser demand, seasonality, video type, and how many views are actually monetized.

Can you make money on YouTube without making videos?

YouTube is fundamentally a video platform, so you still need content that complies with YouTube's policies. Simply uploading reused or copied material is not a reliable monetization strategy. Original, valuable content is important for building a sustainable channel.

Is YouTube Shorts a good way to make money?

Shorts can generate revenue for eligible YPP creators through YouTube's Shorts revenue-sharing system. They can also help attract new viewers who later watch long-form videos, purchase products, use affiliate links, or join a community.

How do small YouTubers make money?

Small YouTubers can potentially earn through affiliate marketing, sponsorships, digital products, services, merchandise, memberships, or other audience-supported methods. They do not necessarily have to wait for substantial ad revenue.

Can YouTube be a full-time income source?

It can become a significant income source for some creators, but there is no guarantee. Revenue depends on audience size, content niche, monetization methods, expenses, consistency, and many other factors.

How long does it take to make money on YouTube?

There is no guaranteed timeline. Some creators generate their first revenue relatively quickly through affiliates or products, while others take months or longer to build enough traffic and audience trust.

What is the easiest way to make money on YouTube?

There is no universally easiest method. Affiliate marketing may be straightforward for product-focused channels, while digital products can work well for educational creators and sponsorships may suit channels with a clearly defined audience. The most practical option depends on what your viewers already want.

Can I make money on YouTube with 100 subscribers?

Yes, potentially through methods that do not require full YPP advertising eligibility, such as affiliate marketing, services, digital products, or sponsorships. However, having 100 subscribers does not guarantee income.